was something to go on. And if we did not go ahead, would we retain the trust of these patriotic young men who were risking their lives to help us out? Would they come to us again or think it to be a waste of time? We needed to give it a try, if only to show our support to these brave youngsters. Jameel's quiet demeanour and intensity of involvement tipped the balance. I gave the executive orders for the plan as outlined by him—task, troops and timings—and Rehan hurried out to pass them to the operational Companies.

The operation was an unqualified success. The cordon parties approached from three different directions under the cover of darkness, the furthermost one first. One party along the main highway, another along a drain that bisected the village, a third in the fields on the fringes of the village. As the main group rushed towards the target house, the terrorists made a break for it, firing wildly in all directions, exactly along the route Jameel had predicted, straight into the trap laid for them. A volley of fire from our side and then deathly silence. A search of the area revealed that we had killed two foreign terrorists of the dreaded Lashkar-e-Toiba group and injured another, who later succumbed to his injuries. This tanzeem was made up mostly of mercenaries from Pakistan and other Islamic countries, including Afghanistan, and which would, post 9/11, be banned by the US. Amidst the congratulations, backslapping and general bonhomie following a successful operation, I could not but help think that the credit was entirely Jameel's. It was his sensibleness and self-belief that had given me the determination, courage and resolve to go ahead, and not the Adjutant's inconsequential titbits of information.

Three months later, Jameel was dead.

Shot dead by terrorists on the first day of the new year, while having his morning cup of tea. In full view of his family.

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